

From M-21-31 to M-26-14: What CISOs need to do now

Executive summary

OMB Memorandum M-26-14 resets the entire federal logging framework, rescinds M-21-31, and ties your agency's security posture directly to two operational outcomes: Continuous Event Monitoring (CEM) and Threat Hunting, Investigation, Response & Forensics (THIRF).

M-26-14 sets a new compliance baseline for cybersecurity logging across US federal agencies, shifting to a risk-based, outcome-driven approach. Agencies that already operate with unified, flexible, and AI-powered platforms like Elastic are better positioned to meet the memo's requirements. With CISA guidance still forthcoming, now is the time for agency leaders to assess current capabilities, identify gaps, and build a prioritized action plan. Elastic is uniquely well-positioned to help CISOs accelerate M-26-14 compliance at scale. Our platform — authorized at FedRAMP High and Moderate levels — provides one platform for both CEM and THIRF, as well as a distributed data mesh architecture and affordable data tiering model that aligns with the M-26-14 move toward federated data models and interoperability.

As agencies wait for CISA to release its logging reference architecture (LRA), CISOs can get ahead by partnering with Elastic to map their strategies now.

Key compliance deadlines (all timers start when CISA publishes the LRA)

90 days after LRA	Submit Agency Logging Plan to OMB and CISA
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120 days after LRA	Achieve maturity Level 1 across all systems
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180 days after LRA	Achieve maturity Level 2 across all systems
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320 days after LRA	Achieve maturity Level 3 (Advanced) across all systems (the memo's primary target state)
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M-26-14 vs. M-21-31: What changed?

M-21-31, which was put in place to help federal agencies strengthen cybersecurity posture by retaining their logs, gave agencies a useful foundation for log management and storage, encouraging SIEM adoption, and enacting log storage requirements.

But agencies also ran into significant obstacles: high storage and licensing costs for growing log volumes, siloed tools that made cross-system analysis difficult, inconsistent log formats that created friction during investigations, and legacy systems that didn't fit neatly into the tiering model.

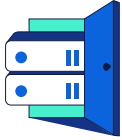
M-26-14 changes the approach: Rather than prescribing specific log types or formats, M-26-14 organizes all logging requirements around two operational outcomes. **CEM** and **THIRF** sit at the center of the memo — they are the standard every agency logging plan, maturity assessment, and LRA requirement is designed to support.

CEM	THIRF
Continuous collection, normalization, and analysis of event data across agency systems, maintaining visibility as conditions change and catching unusual activity before it compounds	Proactive hunting for indicators, reconstructing timelines, responding with context, and preserving a defensible forensic record for oversight and cross-agency coordination

Both require the same foundation: logs that are complete, searchable, normalized, protected, and retained long enough to matter under pressure. In addition to reorienting around CEM and THIRF, M-26-14 makes additional substantial shifts:

Dimension	M-21-31 (Rescinded)	M-26-14 (May 2026)
Philosophy	Comprehensive retention to enable investigation	Risk-based prioritization around two named objectives: CEM and THIRF
Retention model	12 months hot/18 months cold (EL1+); 30 months total at higher tiers	6 months searchable + 12 months retrievable as the minimum baseline
Maturity tiers	EL0–EL3 (Not Effective → Advanced)	Level 0–4 (Ineffective → Optimal); scored per system, lowest watermark wins
Scope of “system”	IT systems	Explicitly includes IoT and OT as part of information systems
Centralization	Strong push toward centralized log aggregation	Centralized, federated, or hybrid — agency choice, with top-level SOC visibility required
Reference architecture	None mandated	CISA must publish Logging Reference Architecture (LRA) within 90 days; agencies align to it
Plan	Implementation plan due to OMB	Agency Logging Plan due to OMB and CISA within 90 days of LRA publication
AI	Not addressed	LRA must address AI methods for CEM/THIRF
Log access	Sharing language (“as needed”)	Explicit obligation to provide logs to CISA/FBI on request during known/suspected compromise
Sensitive data	Less explicit	LRA must include guidance on avoiding incidental capture of sensitive data

Elastic: A unified platform for M-26-14 compliance



Searchable data at scale

Tiered storage keeps active logs fast and searchable while moving older data to lower-cost tiers without sacrificing retrievability. According to an [ESG study](#), organizations migrating from legacy security products to Elastic Security reported a 42%–56% reduction in total cost of ownership.



Distributed data mesh architecture

Elastic's [data mesh architecture](#) aligns with M-26-14's decentralized storage model. Agencies can keep logs where they reside — across cloud, on-premises, and mission systems — while SOC analysts retain centralized search access. Elastic has run this model for CISA's CDM Dashboard for years.



Unified, AI-powered CEM and THIRF

Elastic unifies SIEM, XDR, and native automation, providing prevention, detection, investigation, and response in one platform, eliminating the need to tool-switch during cybersecurity incidents. Using Elastic Security, your team can begin CEM and THIRF activities immediately, with no additional modules or apps to purchase. Autonomous AI agents can handle the full lifecycle from ingestion through response. Your analysts handle judgment, verification, and approval. Elastic provides out-of-the box AI skills, such as for triage, hunting, detection, entity analytics, and investigation, that invoke each other and extend to external AI agents. And instead of constant alerts, AI capabilities reduce the noise by prioritizing the items that need their attention immediately.



Open standards

Native OpenTelemetry (OTel) support lets agencies collect from legacy systems, IoT, and OT without adding proprietary dependencies — important in mixed federal infrastructure environments, and it simplifies log sharing with CISA and the top-level SOC.



Alignment with CISA's SIEM as a Service

Elastic Security powers [CISA's own SIEM-as-a-Service offering](#), giving FCEB agencies access to Elastic's full security platform at no cost. Agentic AI capabilities cover threat triage, alert enrichment, natural-language hunting, and automated response workflows.

Next steps

The planning window is open now — before CISA publishes the LRA and the compliance clock starts.

A focused working session can cover:

- Mapping current logging posture against M-26-14 requirements
- Identifying gaps and prioritizing CEM and THIRF quick wins
- Developing a draft Agency Logging Plan framework

Reach out now to connect with our federal team: elastic.co/contact/public-sector